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Making futuristic laser guns

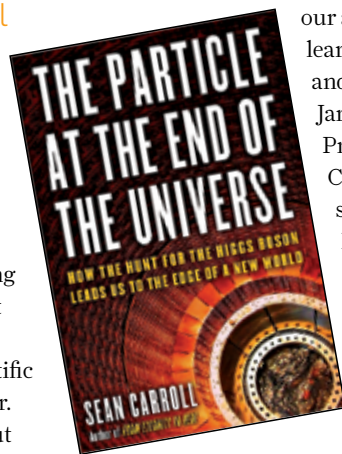
A teenager made a laser gun with a combined power of 40W. Check it out here: <http://dgit.in/1KSIdR3>

as survival machines acting as a sort of carriers for these genes. Dawkins's ideas are radical, to say the least, and led to much criticism but there's no denying the fact that his book, *The Selfish Gene* is an important contribution to socio-biology. In a time when not much was known about genes and DNA specifics, Dawkins presented a model to explain evolution of animal intelligence and altruism.

8 The Particle at the End of the Universe

by Sean Carroll

This book by Sean Carroll talks about the elusive Higgs Boson, the fundamental particle that gives all matter mass. Carroll is an accomplished physicist and blogger and does an excellent job dealing with some complex subject matter, coming up with a thrilling account of a scientific pursuit rivalled by no other. Carroll writes not only about the ideas and theories that predicted the Higgs Boson – discovered at the Large Hadron Collider (LHC) in 2012 – but also the amount of lobbying and politics that were necessary in securing funding for the expensive experiments. He addresses why the search for the particle is an important one and how it adds another piece in the jigsaw of discovering matter. Carroll knows how to condense the subject to the right amount. He explains the basic physics in a way that's never too heavy for the general reader.

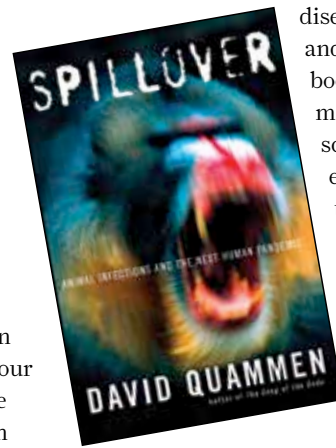


entertaining read, the book delves into the collapse of preceding civilisations such as the Mayans and the developers of the Easter Island statues. Diamond then discusses the factors that lead to the collapse of a society in general and the ability of such a civilisation to self destruct. Diamond, an optimist, also remarks that our civilisation, unlike our ancestors, can learn from mistakes and a collapse can be prevented. Jared Diamond is a Pulitzer Prize winning author and *Collapse* is a brilliantly constructed piece of work. Jared Diamond presents his arguments along with examples and historical evidence. Rather than rely on the generality of the causes of collapse, he notes that all problems don't fit into one framework. One of the longer and heavier books on the list, *Collapse* however has enough content to intrigue you while keeping you captivated and informed.

10 Spillover

by David Quammen

'Spillover' is one of those books from the science genre that has the pace of a typical airport novel. In his thrilling book, Quammen talks about a class of diseases called "zoonotic diseases" that are animal infections and can be passed on to humans. SARS and HIV are two high profile examples of such diseases. *Spillover* is sprawling in scale and scope, but at its heart has a couple of important and ultimately terrifying questions. How do these zoonotic



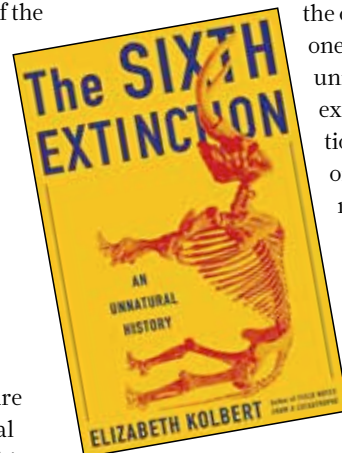
diseases emerge and spread, and what's next? Through the book, we travel across the globe meeting microbe hunters and scientists on the way. It's an exciting and scary ride to say the least. While Quammen doesn't write about dense biological details, he never oversimplifies concepts. The narrative is gripping, and we're presented with anecdotes and stories about people working

(very dangerously) in the field, dealing with deadly diseases as a part of their profession. *Spillover* has the look and feel of a science fiction book. Alas, zoonotic diseases are real and alive.

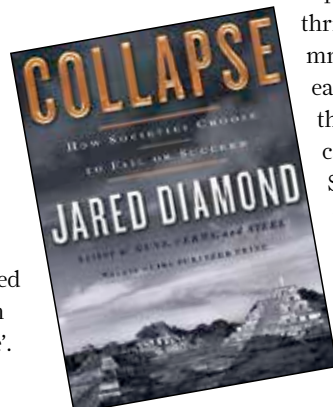
Bonus The Sixth Extinction

by Elizabeth Kolbert

Earth's history has been marked by five mass extinctions that led to sudden depletion in the diversity of living species. 'The Sixth Extinction' refers to the ongoing current one, the one caused by humans, the unnatural one. This book examines the previous extinctions and looks at the current one through a bleak and grim microscope. The author visits sites where species have been wiped out and talks to experts in the field. It's an important book that everyone must read to fully grasp the extent to which humans are



degrading nature. As ecologist Paul Ehrlich quotes, "In pushing other species to extinction, humanity is busy sawing off the limb on which it perches". Kolbert writes in an almost poetic fashion, and the prose is entertaining and beautiful at the same time. The book unfolds in the fashion of a travelogue that carries a clear and concise message and an urgent warning. Although the content presents a highly pessimistic view of the current state of affairs, it's a must read for anyone who's had even a fledgling thought of helping conserve nature's bounties. **[1]**



9 Collapse

by Jared Diamond

How did societies in the past collapse? What are the factors leading to the collapse of entire civilisations? Are we in danger of collapsing as a society? These are the questions Jared Diamond aims to answer in his brilliant book, 'Collapse'. Almost written as multiple books combined into one